Who Can Confirm What

Fifteen questions for your wife's doctor, nurse, therapist and social worker, and for any place you talk to, with room to write what they say.

Part of what your wife needs is yours to describe, because you've seen her days. Part of it belongs to the people who assess her. This page sorts the questions by who can answer each one.

Bring it with you, ask the questions as they're written, and put the answer under each. The page doesn't answer them and doesn't say which matters most. That depends on your wife, and the people below are the ones who know her situation.

The hospital social worker or discharge planner

The person who has started talking with you about where your wife goes next. It may be a social worker, a nurse or another member of the hospital staff.

1. When you say “assisted living” or “memory care,” what help are you expecting my wife to need there?

2. Who on her care team has assessed what she needs, and can we have what they found in writing?

3. What still has to be confirmed about her care before a setting is chosen, and who confirms it?

4. Here is what each of us in the family can realistically do. Where should that be recorded in her planning?

The doctor

1. Here is the help we give her at home, task by task. Which of it do you confirm she requires now?

2. Are there medical or nursing capabilities you'd say any arrangement must have for her, and can you put them in writing?

3. What about her need for supervision has to be assessed, and who does that assessment?

4. Is there anything about how her needs may change that we should ask each place about?

The nurse

1. What does the staff help her with here across a day and a night, and at what times?

2. How does she let the staff know what she needs, and what helps when that is hard for her?

The therapist, if one is involved

1. What help does she need to stand, walk and move between bed, chair and toilet, and what equipment does she use?

2. Will she need therapy to continue, and is that something to ask any arrangement about?

Any arrangement you talk to

A home care agency, an assisted living community, a memory care unit or a nursing home. Ask each one in the same words and write down what they say. Comparing the answers belongs to the step after this one.

1. Here is the help my wife needs, task by task. Which of these do you provide, who provides it, and at what hours?

2. If her needs change while she is with you, what happens, and who decides?

Your care consultant

Someone who helps turn what has been assessed into the kind and amount of assistance to ask for, and flags what still needs a clinician to confirm.

1. Looking at what we've written down and what her care team has confirmed, what is still an open question?

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't answer these questions or put them in order of importance, and it doesn't say what the answers add up to: which kind of care, or which place. If one of them feels pressing to you, say so to the person you're talking with.

Ready for the next step?

You have your questions sorted by who can answer them, and soon you'll have some answers. The care interview gives those answers somewhere to go: it walks you through your wife's daily life area by area and turns what you know into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

Several of these questions follow ones the National Institute on Aging and the Family Caregiver Alliance suggest families ask. The grouping by role is ours.

1. National Institute on Aging, How To Choose a Nursing Home or Other Long-Term Care Facility
2. Family Caregiver Alliance, Residential Care Options: Choosing the Right Place
3. Family Caregiver Alliance, Hospital Discharge Planning: A Guide for Families and Caregivers

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